

The Garden Treasure of Friendship

Hidden treasure story • 3-4 years old



Mia, Lola, Nora, and Zoe were four little girls with four bright backpacks and four bouncy steps. They met in the garden behind Mia's house, where the grass felt soft like a blanket and the air smelled like warm flowers.

Mia held up a crinkly, old-looking paper. "Look," she whispered. "A map!"

Lola's eyes got big. "Is it a treasure map?"

Nora leaned close. The paper smelled a bit like dusty books. "There's an X," she said, tapping gently.

Zoe listened. A sparrow chirped. Leaves shushed in the breeze. "A secret," she whispered, smiling.

The map showed a path: past the red slide, under the apple tree, around the fountain, and to the tall hedge with the tiny wooden door.

"Ready?" asked Mia.

"Ready!" said all four, together.

They marched to the red slide. It was shiny and warm from the sun. At the bottom, they found a little ribbon tied to a stone.

Lola picked it up. The ribbon felt smooth like silk. A small note was tucked under it.

Mia opened the note. "It says: 'Brave feet, gentle hearts. Clap three times.'"

Nora looked unsure for one tiny moment. Then she took a deep breath. "We can do it," she said.

They stood in a circle and clapped. One, two, three.

A soft "click" came from the slide's side, like a quiet toy sound. A small flap

popped open, and inside was a blue button.

Zoe giggled. "A clue button!"

Mia read the next tiny words on the flap. "Press the button and say a kind word."

Lola pressed the button. Nora said, "Friend." Zoe said, "Sharing." Mia said, "Together."

The button glowed for a second, then went dark. A paper arrow slid out like a tongue from a mailbox. It pointed to the apple tree.

They ran to the apple tree. It smelled sweet and green. Fallen apples made the ground bumpy. Nora almost tripped, but Zoe held her hand.

"I've got you," Zoe said.

Nora smiled. "Thank you."

On the tree trunk was a small pocket tied with string. Lola pulled it open carefully. Inside was a tiny bell and another note.

Mia rang the bell. It made a bright, happy "ding-ding."

The note said, "Ring once. Then listen."

They all went still. They listened with their whole faces.

Drip... drip... came a sound, gentle and slow.

"The fountain!" whispered Zoe.

They followed the drip sound to the fountain. The water sparkled and smelled cool, like wet stone after rain. Little drops kissed their hands when they leaned

close.

Around the fountain were four stepping stones, each with a picture: a sun, a moon, a star, and a heart.

Nora pointed. "Four stones. Four girls."

Mia read the map again. "It says: 'Step in order: sun, moon, star, heart.'"

Lola frowned. "What if we do it wrong?"

Mia's voice was soft. "We can try. And we can try again. We stay together."

That made Lola's shoulders relax.

They stepped: Mia on the sun, Lola on the moon, Nora on the star, Zoe on the heart. The stones were cool and a little slippery, but their hands held tight.

A low rumble came, not scary, just like a sleepy tummy. Then—plop!—a small wooden box rose from a hidden spot near the water.

Zoe clapped. "We found it! We found it!"

The box was smooth and smelled like pine. On top was a simple lock with four colored circles: red, yellow, blue, and green.

Lola looked worried again. "We don't have a key."

Nora's eyes scanned the garden. "Maybe the key is... us."

Mia remembered the blue button. "And the ribbon. And the bell."

Zoe opened her backpack. "We can use what we found."

They searched their pockets and held their items like treasures already: the

ribbon, the blue button, the bell, and the paper map.

On the box was a rhyme, written in big, easy letters:

“Red for brave,

Yellow for bright,

Blue for kind,

Green for right.”

Mia nodded. “We need brave, bright, kind, and right.”

Lola stood taller. “I can be brave.” She touched the red circle.

Nora smiled. “I can be bright.” She touched the yellow circle.

Zoe squeezed Mia’s hand. “We can be kind.” Mia touched the blue circle.

Mia looked at her friends. “And we can do what’s right... together.” Zoe touched the green circle.

Click.

The box opened with a gentle sigh.

Inside was not gold or jewels. Inside was something even better for four little girls: four shiny friendship bracelets, soft as yarn and bright as candy. There was also a small card that smelled like clean paper.

Mia read the card out loud. “This treasure grows when you share it. Make a friendship pact.”

Lola picked up a bracelet. “A pact is a promise,” she said, proud.

Nora nodded. "A promise to help."

Zoe said, "A promise to listen."

Mia said, "A promise to stay together."

They each slipped on a bracelet. It felt snug and cozy on their wrists.

They put their hands in the middle, bracelets touching.

"Friendship pact," whispered Mia.

"Friendship pact," whispered Lola, Nora, and Zoe.

The fountain kept dripping softly. Birds sang. The garden smelled sweet and safe. The mystery felt warm now, like a secret hug.

They carried the empty box back to the grass and used it to hold tiny things they found: a smooth pebble, a bright leaf, a fallen pink petal.

"This can be our treasure box," said Zoe.

"Our shared treasure," said Nora.

"Our together treasure," said Lola.

Mia smiled at all three. "And the best treasure is us."

They lay on the soft grass, bracelets shining in the sun, and listened to the calm, happy sounds of their garden adventure.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Who are the four friends in the story?

- Mia, Lola, Nora, and Zoe
- Anna, Ben, Carl, and Dan
- Tom, Tim, Ted, and Timmy
- Lucy, Lily, Lana, and Liza

2) Where did the girls find the map?

- In the garden
- At school
- In a library
- On a bus

3) What did they find inside the wooden box?

- Friendship bracelets
- Gold coins
- A big toy
- A puppy

4) What did the bracelets help them remember?

- To be together and kind
- To run very fast
- To eat candy
- To sleep all day

Correct answers:

1) Mia, Lola, Nora, and Zoe 2) In the garden 3) Friendship bracelets 4) To be together and kind

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Crinkly: Makes a soft crackling sound, like old paper when you touch it.

Old-looking: Looks like it has been around a long time and is not new.

Whispered: Spoke very quietly so only nearby friends can hear.

Tucked: Put something snugly under or inside a small place.

Sparrow: A small brown bird that sings and hops on branches.

Pocket: A small place to hold things, like on a jacket or tree tied bag.

Stepping stones: Flat stones placed to step on across water or mud.

Slippery: Smooth and easy to slide on, so you must hold tight.

Rumble: A low, rolling sound like a soft tummy or distant drum.

Rhyme: Words that sound the same at the end, like cat and hat.

Pact: A simple promise between friends to do something together.

Bracelets: Bands worn around the wrist that can be pretty and soft.

Treasure map: A paper that shows where to find a special, hidden thing.

Hidden spot: A small place that is out of sight and kept secret.